

Bears

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Carnivora
FAMILY	Ursidae
SPECIES	8

The bear family includes the world’s largest terrestrial carnivore, the brown bear, which can stand up to 11 ft (3.5 m) tall. Bears have a heavy build, a large skull, thick legs, and a short tail. They are found throughout Eurasia and North America, and in parts of North Africa and South

America, mainly in forests. Unlike most carnivores, bears rely heavily on vegetation as a food source.

Anatomy

Bears are either large or medium-sized, and males are up to 20 percent larger than females. Although the giant panda is one notable exception, most bears have a black, brown, or white coat, and many feature a white or yellow mark on the chest. Despite the fact that they have a keen sense of smell, bears’ sight and hearing are less well developed, and this is reflected in their large snout and small eyes and ears.

Most bears have lost the carnassial (shearing) function of the molar teeth. Instead, the molars are flat with rounded cusps, making them effective tools for grinding vegetation. Bears have large, strong paws—a single blow can often kill another animal—and long, nonretractable claws.

Movement

Compared with other carnivores, bears walk slowly and deliberately, with all 5 toes as well as their heels touching the ground (plantigrade gait). They can, however, move quickly if the need arises. When threatened or defending their territory, many bears stand on their back legs to increase their already considerable size. The majority of bears are agile climbers.

Feeding

The diet of most bears consists of a mixture of meat (including insects and fish) and plant material (from roots and shoots to fruit and nuts). Only the polar bear lives exclusively on meat, while the giant panda is almost entirely herbivorous. Brown bears have a capacity to eat almost continuously without feeling full, prior to becoming dormant in winter. Because bears depend on plants more than other carnivores, they spend more of their time feeding. Most forage during the day.

Dens and dormancy

Many bears, especially those in cold regions, become dormant in winter. During this time, they retreat to a prepared den and live on reserves of body fat. This state differs from true hibernation (see p.89), which involves a drop in body temperature. Cubs are often born during dormancy. Since they have no fur, the newborn cubs are highly vulnerable and benefit from the snug environment created by their mother’s body heat.

CONSERVATION

Of the 8 species of bears, only one—the giant panda—is officially listed as endangered. However, 5 are classified as vulnerable. Polar bears are particularly vulnerable in the southern parts of their range because global warming is melting the Arctic sea ice where they spend the winter, feeding on seals and breeding. The southern Beaufort Sea population has declined by over 40 percent since 2001.

PHYSICAL INTIMIDATION

Bears can be aggressive animals, particularly when competing with each other during the breeding season. When male brown bears come into conflict, they will often try to intimidate one another by making themselves look as large as possible, growling and displaying their teeth. Smaller individuals will usually give way to larger ones, but if a warning is ignored, actual fighting will break out, often leading to serious injury or death.

